

HARVARD BUSINESS SCHOOL

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT HARVARD

The Harvard Business School has a brand like no other business school in the world. And it is this magnetic appeal that persuades over 9000 hopefuls to compete for one of the roughly 940 places in its MBA program. The HBS Admissions team is made up of only five key individuals. Such limited staff resources may in part explain the school's move towards a shorter, more streamlined application in recent years. HBS now only requires two recommendations, and in the past three years has moved from four essays down to just one essay. Your resume and recommendations have never carried so much weight.

HBS has more CEOs of Fortune 500 companies than any other MBA program, a couple of former Presidents (U.S. and Mexico), and an unrivaled global network of influence. This conservative symbol of success, with its old red brick campus and the highest admissions yield, nevertheless faces a battle to win the hearts of minds of the tech industry. For many applicants, the closest they will get to a Harvard MBA is a T-shirt, but for a select few it will be the experience of a lifetime.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

With a world-renowned faculty, HBS can claim academic excellence in many fields. Perhaps best known for General Management and a dedication to the case method, the school touts Leadership, Entrepreneurship, Strategy and CSR among the top areas of study.

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	2	-	8	1	1	-	3	6
Financial Times	2	1	1	1	2	4	3	3
Forbes	-	1	-	3	-	2	-	4
The Economist	4	6	6	4	4	4	3	4
US News	1	1	1	2	1	1	1	1

CLASS OF 2021		ADMISSIONS	
Number of Applicants	9228	Avg Age	27
MBA Class Size	938	Avg GMAT	730
Yield	85%	Avg GPA	3.7
Total Tuition	\$146,880	Int'l Students	37%

POST-MBA CAREERS	
Financial Services	29%
Consulting	21%
Technology	20%
Consumer Products	6%
Starting a Business	7%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:
McKinsey, Goldman Sachs, BCG, Bain, Morgan Stanely

AVERAGE BASE SALARY:	US\$146,880
EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS:	94%

*Rankings are relative to other U.S. business schools. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR HARVARD APPLICATION

BY MALVINA MILLER COMPLAINVILLE

One of Fortuna's resident Harvard Business School experts, Malvina is former Assistant Director of Career Services at HBS. As Head of the HBS Programs and Communication team she was responsible for providing career training and guidance to students, and as a member of the career coaching team she has spent literally hundreds of hours coaching students on how to achieve their post-MBA goals.

In addition to an extensive background in career development, Malvina also brings rich experience in talent management and campus recruiting from her time at LVMH and L'Oréal USA.



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1

STAND OUT FROM YOUR PEER GROUP

Given the thousands upon thousands of candidates that HBS gets to choose from, successful candidates are those who manage to show how they stand out from the crowd. The HBS admissions team puts a great deal of effort into crafting a diverse and dynamic classroom, with individuals who will bring perspective and experience that is different from their fellow classmates. Candidates who have strong experience but whose profile seems undifferentiated from the hundreds or thousands of other candidates from the same sector are not going to make the cut. So give some deep thought to what is unique about your background and about your potential contribution to the program.

SHOWCASE YOUR LEADERSHIP

2

Leadership is at the core of the Harvard experience. HBS is known as the school for general management training, specifically developing leaders who will “contribute to the well being of society.” The admissions office gives greater weight to leadership experience, and less weight to intellectual horsepower than some other top schools. So when applying to HBS, make sure your leadership experience comes across prominently, not just as a one-off, but as a pattern of leadership that can be demonstrated at different stages of your development.

3

ARTICULATE A CLEAR, AMBITIOUS AND REALISTIC CAREER VISION

Reflect on how your career vision aligns with HBS's values. Your career vision should be detailed, with short-term goals and long-term goals. It should be ambitious and achievable. And if it seems to you that west coast rival Stanford GSB has cornered the market in careers that change lives and change organizations, think again. Harvard is equally interested in finding out what impact you intend to have on an institution, an industry and the world. You should also think of two different paths that could lead you to your long-term career goals; this gives you more flexibility if one of your short-term goals prove challenging to achieve.

SPEND TIME FINE-TUNING YOUR RESUME

4

The resume is often the first element that the file reader will review, so it needs to pack a punch. And with Harvard now down to only one optional essay your resume has never been more important. Make sure that the strength of your credentials comes across very strongly. Highlight your achievements and the impact you had in your roles. Quantify your achievements and impact with specific numbers wherever possible. HBS is looking for candidates on a rapid career trajectory, so make sure your evolution (promotions, increasing scope of responsibility, etc.) is clearly demonstrated. You may want to consider adopting the HBS resume format.

5

DEMONSTRATE STRONG COMMUNICATION SKILLS

Class participation makes up 50% of the student grade. You are expected to speak up confidently and participate actively in class. The case method requires that you listen carefully to the discussion unfolding in the classroom and be prepared to jump in and share an insightful point in a clear and concise manner. In your application, you should think of how you can showcase your strong communication skills – for instance, discuss your success presenting in public and engaging in debates.

ESSAY ANALYSIS



Your opportunity to show them what you are made of, what drives you, is in the essay. The competition is fierce, so this is the place where you can convince them you have what it takes to be part of this incredible community.

Karla Cohen,
Fortuna Admissions Expert Coach & former Associate Director at HBS



ESSAY 1. "As we review your application, what more would you like us to know as we consider your candidacy for the Harvard Business School MBA Program?" (No word limit)

For many applicants, this question feels maddeningly open ended – paralyzing even – given the lack of word limit. Beyond credentials, HBS is looking for character. The Admissions Committee seeks principled, passionate individuals who have the potential to fulfill the HBS mission to education leaders who make a difference in the world.

The essay is often the make or break factor for HBS. Character doesn't show up on a resume, in your test scores, or through grades or your transcripts. Your opportunity to show them what you are made of, what drives you, is in the essay. The competition is fierce, so this is the place where you can convince them you have what it takes to be part of this incredible community. Go deep. Get personal. Make sure the reader feels the genuineness and authenticity of your story. There is "consultant advice" that has been circulated that states it should not exceed 1000-1200 words and that's just patently false. Content is everything and some people's stories need more space.

At the end of the essay the reader should feel so moved they want to meet you immediately – can't wait to get to know you better, hear more of the story, ask you specific questions to learn more, be inspired, etc. Think of drafting almost a "movie trailer" for your life – it should be engaging, interesting, dramatic, and fast-paced.

For more HBS essay tips and advice, view Karla's recent blog, [HBS Essay: 5 Key Tips on What Harvard Really Wants.](#)

DEADLINES & DATES*

	APPLICATION DEADLINE	FINAL DECISIONS
Round 1	8 September 2020	10 December 2020
Round 2	5 January 2020	30 March 2020

*COVID-19

For the latest updates about how COVID-19 is impacting admissions and programming at Harvard and all top MBA programs, please visit our [blog](#).



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances of admission, reserve yours at: FortunaAdmissions.com

